

Reading Group 1 - arising questions

Personal racial consciousness:

How do we as a project build up our stamina to stay with a conversation about race? What do we need to do as a project to have that discourse?

How can we better understand our own personal unconscious bias?

How do we most effectively and honestly address/acknowledge the whiteness of our project team?

Me and White Supremacy Group

Next run of reading groups - to support us to collectively develop a decolonising approach

Conceptual-political:

What forms of work on decoloniality might be helpful for us conceptually?

What are the conceptual shifts we need to make?

Interested in the language of race and ethnicity, why it is used and how we navigate it when the overall goal is to dissolve race?

Structuring CE project / Different perspectives:

How can we involve researchers/projects who are already working in these areas? Can the CE investigations be a place/space to do this?

How do we involve (or invite?) the whole of Congruence Engine in this discussion?

Social Machine:

How can CE specifically, with its concerns and methodology, uniquely address these issues? -

At what stages in the digital pipelines are decolonising interventions most relevant/productive - Where do these considerations sit in our work on the social machine?

How can we ensure our ontologies are not too western-focused and colonially influenced; especially new ones we develop throughout the project? How do we create counter-colonial data resources: taxonomies and language models?

How do we digitally represent and structure the knowledge generated in this project, and what terminologies do we use, to promote decolonisation and surface this kind of knowledge?

Bradford Convergence - enacting social machine

Digital decolonisation: What stories do the datasets we are working with enable us to tell?

What are their limits in terms of asking questions about decolonising collections?

What are the limits of the digital tools as tools of decolonising collections?

How other digital humanities projects engaged with questions of decolonialisation|and/or decolonising collections?

As ML itself is extractive, how do we conscientiously use it? Links to racialisation in aspects of how ML is trained? Do the digital tools/techniques need to be decolonised? How possible is it to decolonise tools/techniques given the black box nature of some of them?

**Reading
Group 2 -
arising
questions**

Q: How can different traditions of majority-world / experiential knowledge combine/interact with western 'public' open ideals?

Q: Does contingent and local mean small? Or do we need to decolonise ideas of scale? (more examples, sustained)

Q: The tools of enlightenment seen as coterminous with colonialism? STS / HPS local and contingent not universal? Careful not to (maybe) not throw the baby out with the bathwater...

Q: How might we de-centre whiteness?

different forms of slaing

How free are we to explore this given TANC funding?

Legitimacy of reasons to resist access and governance around that.

Issues to be aware of in this question: gatekeeping etc / Important not to give institutions a reason to say no

Q: How can we challenge the assumptions towards openness and publicness that is not always appropriate for indigenous and other forms of (autonomous) knowin

Q: How do we attune to the erasure of local indigenuity in Britain that happened with the industrial revolution?

Responsible openness

Choosing not to be included and being excluded

Reading Group 3

How can these changes be meaningful and long-lasting? How can this include changes in how people work and think?

How can work in this area be seen as interactive and emergent?

How can an emergent and evolving approach also keep visible the histories of violence embedded in cataloguing? (e.g. non-violent protests being seen as 'riots')

"within a decolonised system, those with academic specialisms would no longer be understood as the leading authority over material

that is not from their cultural background or related to their lived experience."

How can we link what we have (already with documentation systems) to richer and more complex understandings?

How do we not assume what communities want / want to do?

neutrality

Not just blatantly racist words - also misunderstanding of cultural context in general description

'Gatekeeping' - might be reasons why people want to be protected and keep knowledge closed

Difficulty of starting the work and lack of reflective practice about race happening on the ground

How can the application of descriptors be responsive to how people think of themselves?

How can this not just be framed in terms of 'adding' but also as 'unpicking' the colonality of stories that are there?

How might we recognise and design for the tension between some people wanting valued for lived experience and other people feeling boxed in?

How do we move away from a disempowered discourse that enables action and movement?

How do we navigate the desire from those in power for people to be legible only in certain kind of ways ('international' 'BAME')?

How do we avoid not having the same conversation over and over again that doesn't progress anti-racist practice?

holding space for accountability while also moving forward with anti-racist, decolonial approaches?

whose experience and whose knowledge gets to inform documentation practices?

How to document the decision-making around an exhibition or other processes (in terms of approaches to race)?

Can liberal organisations (forged in the legacies of coloniality) reform rather than co-opt and contain?

Emotional labour placed on people of colour in doing institutional work

Will other modes of deinstitutionalised modes of organising and being be needed?

What do we have to do to move beyond conversations that feel repetitive?

Reading Group 4

Jenny Bulstrode

Innovation in metal work in Africa - machinery imported back to UK

Tension - it's all about them and what it means to them. But she is saying innovation can take place in enclosed, illiberal environments (not free minds and weak state)

Is this the case with iron - what might this mean for textiles?

Designs - stolen from Africa

How to integrate the global and colonial dimensions?

How to build in considerations of race?

Stefania - in terms of sources: songs, place, stories attached to place, pantomime, living histories and oral histories, some forms of memory still alive in community

CE we often start with data collection. But we need different sources, not just those in museums and archives? Different type of evidence.

Bradford migration to work in the textiles - relatively hidden history

Tim - Opening up of our global sense on CE topic. Some stronger claims that the evidence seemed to support.

Make a few leaps and links - important when there is little evidence

Arran - looking at collections that were cited. Only one Jamaican collections, rest UK and European. Devon Heritage Centre - so array. But still not more non-UK?

Nina - what the article was supposed to be about and what it was about? Relates to why this is the race and decolonisation group, so it's a mindset, prompting a rethinking.

Oliver Jelf - Rebuttle tone - that tone makes me ask what is his investment in such a stern rebuttle? Why not sit with that and consider what it offers in terms of the questions we ask?

Daria - collective knowledge, rather than that idea of invention as individual genius

Wikimedia - easier if it's one person and clear provenance. It makes me ask how we approach knowledge?

Arran - last conversation how we enable different knowledge to be documented, but limits in western history of what counts as valid... stuck in a loop of oppression

Stephanie - decolonisation is about how we conceptualise knowledge, how to not reinforce classificatory systems that have always been used.

Sources - double tension, we are looking for big data sources, but the sort of source are not regular.

Language - criminal nature of enslavement

Graph databased - can deal with different perspectives

Greggs - archives at NT and Manchester. Starting with big collections

What if when we look for 'easiest' machine readable sources we miss the kind of sources we are looking for?

Eric Williams

Race as product of slavery not a cause of it

Slavery ended for economic reasons not humanitarian reasons

Innovation happening this regulated environment and only when sugar became unprofitable

Stuart - wikipedia, Bulstrode's work, read rebuttles and criticisms, made some good points about use of sources and quotes

Giving list of names, relevant to our project

Stuart Prior (Guest) 14:23
SP I think one important thing we can take from Bulstrode's work (and many others) is in language where it relates to our work. Such as describing the slave trade in criminal terms such as the abduction and enslavement of people, not the commercial language of "buying and selling slaves"

Tim Boon (External) 14:39

TB I think she makes a good case for SKILLS when the old fashioned accounts are obsessed with technical INNOVATION.

Alex Fitzpatrick (External) 14:35

AF noticed that the rebuttal got picked up by the worst parts of history studies on social media too - even if the criticisms are technically sound it's hard not to be like

Stuart Prior (Guest) 14:36

SP yeah I thought Bulstrode's piece challenged some sacred cows of UK industrial history like the "workshop of the world" idea

Alex Fitzpatrick (External) 14:40

AF it's so funny coming to this from archaeology where we're all working from the smallest bits of evidence (literally)

Alex Butterworth 14:48

AB And where the (re)construction of enslaved experience (in the classical world, for example) from the most fragmentary evidence has required a high degree of formal narrative invention: to signal the uncertainty inherent in the evidential 'marginality' Something we probably need to consider in this context.

Approaches
session, 22nd
Nov

**Data
itself**

Who
produced the
data? Where?
For what
purposes?

How can we
mitigate the
colonial
structures
intrinsic in the
data?

Recognition
'museums are not
neutral' but are we
applying that to
collections data

**How we
set events
up**

**White
supremacy
assumptions
we bring to
investigations**

Transparency of one's
positionality as part of
our overall
accountability as a
project is interesting -
especially as we are
working on so many
layers of engagement
and negotiation with

4, What was
the function
of the African
Mines
directory?

and
identifying
the types of
suggested
interventions

Politics of
datafication - not all
knowledge can be
turned into data, not
all people want to
be turned into data

Conceptual challenge
to modes of
knowledge (beyond
rational/emprical/dis-
embodied, personal,
emotional)

**What questions do
we need to ask to
create an anti-racist
and anti-oppressive
national collection
as social machine?**

we can also apply the
notion of "consent to
datafication" to the
notion of the social
machine as well as far
as understanding that
we cannot "force" a
community, a

**What question
we need to ask to
treat the materials
we are working with
as a record of UK
colonial and
capitalist expansion
and contraction?**

'a sort of violence'
around datafication
- all sort of upstream
biases that we not
able to reckon with
yet

**Goes to
training -
not deficit
model**

**Conceptual
challenges to
national
boundary**

Conceptual
challenge to
collection /
dataset

**How can we
include other
(often
unwritten)
forms of
knowledge?**

reading for
the normative
(not only
absences)

**Collaborative
relationships
(actively not
extractive)**

**Biases in
technology
itself**

1, What are the
limits of a "national"
collection if the
items are located
outside the national
borders?

To what extent do
the holders of these
historical items see
the items to belong
to a "national
collection" located
elsewhere?

2, Where colonial
legacies still persist
within UK collections,
to what extent can
the datafication of
directories can
highlight the
entry-points for the
decolonisation of colle

3, What colonial
representations have
persisted in maps
showing the locations
of these mines? And
how can digital tools
help with highlighting
them, initiating
dialogues about them,

**Seek out other
data/stories**

5, Who were the
main companies
and manufacturers
funding and
equipping the
mines?

6, Which mines and
stories are
represented most
often in the
historical
imagination and
historical
scholarship?

How is this reflected
in the distribution of
items within
historical
collections?

**Material
realities of
using these
technologies**

Reading Group 5

**Racial
Capitalism**

**Need for
racialisation and
racial
hierachicalisation to
justify enslavement**

**Catherine
Hall's focus on
long is
effectively
using white
centred data**

**Responsibility
and debt
(ongoing
debt)**

Reading Group 6

plurality still
relies on the
idea of a
universal
perspective

SZL: Wonders how
we can also explore
the whiteness
embedded in the AI
systems (alongside
the archives and
data, there are also
the techniques that
we are using?

SP/Wikipedia
labelling: my
understanding is its
value is better
awareness of
provenance,
attribution, the idea
of a "default" or
institutional voice

e.g are all white
perspectives white
perspectives and
vice versa?

AF: 'there's
definitely a tension
of resources/time of
a project vs what is
needed to properly
undertake those
conversations.'

or perspective, and
what might be in
the negative space
created by
whiteness. How we
can apply this
practically?

AF: I think its about
thinking of those
"empty spaces" in
data where
whiteness is
presumed
normative

Race and
Decolonisation
Research Discussion
Group 1 (2024)

Would engineers
and computer
programmers today
think it is not part of
the culture?

Tone of the text
overall; if it was
written today and
not in 2007 would it
be written
differently?

Consideration of
whether or not the
use of the 'everyday'
language to explain
technical terms to
lay persons is
offensive to them?

NLP certainly made
it very hard to make
the case that it's
'not relevant' to
consider ethical
questions in
engineering etc

The primary name for
this on Wikidata is not
m/s it's
primary/replica
<https://www.wikidata.org/wiki/Q735523>

**A more
nuanced
discussion
now about
systemic
inequalities?**

Action Research:
Changing the
language of the
environment over
the next year - does
this have an impact
on the environment
itself

**Tag Lab work:
use of the
phrase
'master' in the
spreadsheet**

Was this adopted
top down? Or has it
seeped into use
(vernacular culture
at work) - which
could be more
insidious. Rather
than accidental or
innocent.

Does adopting new
metaphors or
phrasing change the
actual dynamics of
the conversations
we are having?
What are the power
dynamics?

How are we tracking
things, like use of
language, in the
Congruence Engine
project?

A really useful piece of
work to do (wider
ethical
dimensions/responsi-
bility) - terms being
used across
regions/disciplines -
keeping
documentation

the Python language
removed master/slave
terminology in 2018
<https://www.vice.com/en/article/8x7akv/master-slave-terminology-was-removed-from-python-programming-language> SP

Coding discourse - a
sense that its not
really to do with
them/part of doing
communities. Bad
faith arguments:
Master/Slave (good
in the BDSM
community!)

Sometimes these
conversation gets lost
as simply "renaming
things" but we should
think about this as an
ethical -first step
toward tackling deep
underlying issues in
collections

It would be
important to frame
all this discussion &
practice into an
"ethics of care"
framework

Relationship to
other forms of
discrimination.
"Brogrammers" v.s
strong movements
around producing
inclusivity and
diversity in
technology.

Google
programming
camps - focusing on
tone and voice of
programming
language

<https://ifte.network/full-stack-feminism/>

Different in colonial
contexts (S. Africa)
more use of
religious and greek
mythical language

When did this
language become
resurgent? Note
about when they
became popular.

This terminology was
used for ants -
pre-civil war. On the
ants, if you're
interested:
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/26741208>

Stuart (Guest) 3:28 PM

S again, slightly tangential but
statuary brings us back to
classical language and imagery
mentioned by Bernard
<https://castinstone.exeter.ac.uk/en/2023/12/22/roman-style-statues-as-an-exercise-of-colonial-power-in-britain/>



Graeme Gooday (External) 3:45 PM

GG Fascinating seeing the range of
binaries Stuart; master/slave

- primary/secondary
- leader/follower
- master/slave model
- source/replica
- master/standby
- master/minion
- controller/peripheral
- master-slave
- master-detail
-

Graeme makes the
point that language
of 'slavery' was used
in the UK to try to
end child labour -
some suggestions
child labour was
worse/more
abominable

Richard Oastler -
Bradford and District
Local Studies
(bradfordlocalstudies.com)

Race and
Decolonisation
Research Discussion
Group 2 (2024)

Context for this
reading: For the
groups working
around this
<https://cistudies.org>

**All tangible
work to
emerge from
this comes
from this**

What are our plans for
sustainability? (How
to sustain open and
anti-oppressive ways
for us to contribute to
a National Collection.
As well as ecological
sustainability.)

Are there instances
when communities
don't want there
collections to be
digitised? A sense
that in this article
that connection is
powerful, and might
trump this instance.

How does this
article relate to our
consideration of
race and
decolonisation?

Open access and
power dynamics.
Accessibility to wider
global audiences.
Finances and the
impact has on
power. How can we
as a local authority?

Entry points for the
article and CE
project/R+D work:
thinking in general
about global/local,
centre/periphery,
digital divides and
inequalities useful

Global dimension of
infrastructure;
community-led,
non-commercial,
co-creation, open,
diversity. Bringing the
human factor into the
'hard concept' of
human infrastructure

Call out by Arran for
an experiment on
how we create an
open and
anti-oppressive
environment to do
this work

Is there a counter
argument to this - a
counter article?
Something that
posits that we don't
want to connect
everything and
make things part of
a structure.

Infrastructure and
communities want to
represent themselves.
Lizzie shared:
<https://sustainableheritagenetwork.org/digital-heritage/mukurtu-indigenous-archive-to-ol>

Restrictions and
conflicting
requirements with
heritage collections,
pressure to make
money from
collections,
conflicting with
principles about it

1) Access 2)
Connectivity 3)
Standardisation

Suggestion by
Daniel to work
across TaNC with
other Discovery
Projects not to work
from scratch

What about when
sharing contributes
to a central
organisation's
power and
resources or money
continues to flow to
the centre and not
the periphery?

<https://humanitiesforall.org/projects/mukurtu-an-indigenous-archive-and-publishing-tool>

**Purse
strings =
power**

Also interesting for
CE: Thinking of
collaborative and
interdisciplinary
projects as the glue
between these
divides?

Interesting idea -
going back and
forwards about this -
the way it is worked
through in this article;
what did they actually
think about this
(beyond good/bad), is
there more detail?

Open access for
publicly owned
collections. Yes. But
when we think
about different kinds
of heritage for
collections that are
not part of
institutions.

**Article misses
a really great
example of
cultural
heritage
logics**

Alex: What is missing?
We are being told we
should be shocked by
the lack of
infrastructure and
resourcing. In this
survey there aren't a
lot of examples to
build on.

Open access is the
answer but also
seems ambivalent
about this. Points
out that there are
issues with larger
presses and open
access but not
solutions

Some things can be
standardised some
things can't. A
nuanced situation,
that could be
explored further...

Thinking about the
violence of
colonialism. Thinking
about issues of
respect and cultural
difference and
different knowledge
systems. Open access
cannot solve all

**Counter
mapping work
in digital
heritage**

Is it looking at critical
interventions? Where
are they happening?
From the grassroots
up? Can we grapple
with the difficulties of
doing this and
incorporating this
work?

Tension between
something that
could be unified and
something that
resists by it

Does everyone
involved in the
process of creating
resources for open
access understand
the legal
dimensions or other
policies and
procedures?

Open access doesn't
get rid of the
centre/periphery
dynamic. There is
not always
understanding
about this.

<https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/impactofsocialsciences/2023/10/11/counter-mapping-how-visualising-landscapes-of-power-can-unravel-dominant-development-narratives/>

Race and
Decolonisation
Research Discussion
Group (3) 2024

Reading:
<https://www.guernicamag.com/miscellaneous-files-ariella-aisha-a-zoulay/>

'Possible histories' -
a literature which
includes speculative
history, strong
stance in rejecting
some of the stances
of established
historical
scholarship

Takes aim at 1)
Temporality - the
pastness of the past,
e.g. as a way of
justifying colonial
violence, 2) Ontology
of the document -
authority given to
written document

Photography - est.
photography as being
intrinsically linked to
imperialism. More
than a technology, a
practice/a way of
thinking/a way of
establishing
knowledge

Theoretical approach
to decolonisation -
feeling a bit
depressed? Not much
to 'do', big questions,
implications -
completely undo
history/museums
approach

Taking aim at
'authority' - academic
audacity. What was
done to victims - and
the knowledge of
what was done -
doesn't 'count'
because it has not
been documented

"It is not possible to
decolonize the
museum without
decolonizing the
world."

Talking about
her new book,
Potential
History:
Unlearning
Imperialism

Born in Israel (of
Algerian decent, Arab
Jew, rejects term
'Israeli'), professor
Brown University, two
previous books
heavily theoretical,
filmmaker, curator -
talks a lot this work

Media,
history,
decolonial
theory

Communicating in
'non-imperial' terms.
What do we think
that is? What does
that mean? And is it
relevant to the work
we do? What does it
mean to us? Possible?
Are we doing it?

Fetishization of the
archive 3) Obsession
with the new,
pursuit of novelty
and new ways of
studying the past.
Colonial violence.

Museums as
concepts/institutional
structures. Taking
western thought
practices and
applying them across
the board to obliterate
any other thought
practices

Geoff: Challenging
and positively so in
ways that decolonial
argumentation that
he has come across,
this work is structural
and systematic (more
than language, fabric
of world)

Implications for CE -
are we going to
change the structures
of the institutions we
work for - is it
decolonial work?
Ways of lighting a fire
for the future of this
research?

Defines what
photographic history
should be - the ways
he has been looking
at - done partially
through Museums
(not explicitly
decolonial) but does
look at meanings

Julia: Personal? A lot
more of an
experiential book that
gives insight - that
other theoretical
books do not do.
Invites us to take a
step/not an example -
to unlearn. Onus on us

Max: We might
expect/lazy reaction
to expect steps to
'unlearn
imperialism' - not a
list but a lot of
thinking to unpack
and understand
implications for us

Tim: Permission. We
have said that we
think that the UK
digital collection
should be created in
those areas where
people want to do the
history. An authority
to tell those history?

Julia: Work is being
done on the ground in
people in Bradford
who have been there,
doing the work, for
decades and allowing
them to tell the
histories they want to
tell

Alex F: Looking at
breaking down words
and terminology. Not
using terminology.
Lots of lukewarm DEI
movements and
terminology. More of a
positive step to
unlearn/breakdown.

Arran: Unpacking
the idea that it is
our right to go into
an archive and tell a
story without those
involved/those
descended from
those who have
experienced this

Nina: implications
for the project - why
we are comfortable
to fill in some
historical gaps with
GPT and why we are
not doing this in
other areas (legacies
of colonialism)?

Think about histories
we can tell, not stop
entirely thinking we
cannot tell a certain
history - but what is
the part of the history
where the actors
(violence of
colonialism) are hidden

Max: A clarity of
thought and
expression. A lot of
writing about
decolonisation is
impenetrable
(historically) - this is
the opposite of that

Challenging the use
of finding a
source/developing a
technology to fill in
gaps. Asking why
we need/want to do
this.

Daniel: What about
history that we do not
want to preserve/or
do not want it to exist,
from those who have
experienced it as
something that they
do not want to
remember?

How does this
inform the
existence of
archives and
archival
practices?

Julia: The voices - the
systemic aspect/the
institutional aspect -
upheld by the
individual actions and
actors. The people
who originally worked
with this/working on
this now are

White people. Think
about systems exist.
How they change or
don't change? We
have certain ideas of
what this practice
looks like - informed
by everything this
article talks about

Imperialist notion
that the entire
concepts that
museums, archives,
collections, and
history - as holders
of power,
knowledge, what
they prioritise

Bernard: questioning
the sources of the
data that we use.
Issue that
archives/documentary
sources/photos are
'key evidence' -
acceptable evidence.

What other ways of
knowing are
side-lined? This could
change the way we
know something/the
way we have learned
history. How do we
account for this
knowledge?